Markdown Glossary

Plain-language meanings for words you will meet while learning Markdown. You do not need to memorize these; come back when a word is unfamiliar.

- **Anchor** — the hidden target that a link to a heading jumps to. For a heading called `Main Results`, the link is often `#main-results`.
- **Backtick** — the `` ` `` character, usually on the key above Tab. Markdown uses it to mark code.
- **Code block (code fence)** — several lines of code or literal text between two lines of three backticks.
- **CommonMark** — a precise written standard for the core of Markdown, so different tools agree on the basics.
- **Commit** — saving a set of changes in Git (or in GitHub's web editor) together with a short message describing them.
- **Compiler** — a program that turns source files into a finished document. Basic Markdown does not need one; you just open a preview.
- **Flavor** — a version of Markdown with extra features, for example GitHub Flavored Markdown, Pandoc Markdown, Quarto, or Obsidian. The basics are the same everywhere; the extras differ.
- **Front matter (YAML)** — a block of settings at the very top of a file, between two lines of `---`. Tools such as Quarto and Pandoc read it; ordinary Markdown viewers may show it as plain text or a small table.
- **Git** — a tool that records the history of changes to the files in a project.
- **GitHub** — a website that stores Git projects and shows Markdown files as formatted pages.
- **GitHub Flavored Markdown (GFM)** — the flavor GitHub uses. It adds tables, task lists, and strikethrough to the basics.
- **HTML** — the language of web pages. Some Markdown tools let you mix a little HTML into your text.
- **Inline code** — a word or short phrase shown in code style by wrapping it in single backticks, such as `analysis.R`.
- **Jupyter / Colab** — notebooks that mix code cells with text cells. The text cells are written in Markdown.
- **KaTeX / MathJax** — tools that draw mathematical formulas in a web page. They are what make `$x^2$` appear as math.
- **LaTeX** — a typesetting system widely used for academic papers. Many Markdown tools borrow its notation for math, but you do not need to learn LaTeX to use Markdown.
- **Markdown** — a way of writing formatted text using ordinary characters, such as `#` for a heading and `**` for bold.
- **Pandoc** — a free program that converts documents between formats, for example Markdown to PDF or Word.
- **Plain text** — a file that contains only characters, with no hidden formatting. Any text editor can open it.
- **Preview** — the formatted view of your Markdown, shown next to or

instead of the source.

- **Quarto** — a publishing system built on Markdown that adds citations, cross-references, and runnable code, and can produce HTML, PDF, or Word output.
- **Raw** — the unformatted source of a file. On GitHub, the **Raw** button shows the Markdown exactly as typed.
- **README** — a file, usually `README.md`, that explains a project. GitHub shows it automatically on the project's front page.
- **Relative path** — the location of a file measured from the file you are writing in, for example `figures/result.png`, or `../data/` to go up one folder first. Relative paths keep working when you move the whole project.
- **Renderer** — the program that turns Markdown source into the formatted result you see. GitHub, VS Code, and Obsidian each have their own renderer.
- **Repository (repo)** — a project folder whose history is tracked by Git, usually stored on GitHub.
- **Source** — the plain Markdown text that you type, before it is formatted.
- **Syntax** — the symbols and patterns that have a special meaning, such as `**bold**` or `- item`.
- **Task list** — a list of checkboxes written as `- [ ] to do` and `- [x] done`.
- **Vault** — in Obsidian, the folder that holds all your notes.
- **VS Code** — a free code editor with a built-in Markdown preview.
- **Wiki link** — a link written as `[[note name]]`. Obsidian and some other tools support it; GitHub does not.